Technology Board Report - March 2026
Director of Technology – Steven Hopper

The Tech Department has embarked on several major product evaluations this month. The first involves our student Chromebook initiative. For the past four years, we have purchased Dell 2-in-1 touchscreen Chromebooks that can be used in either laptop or tablet mode at a cost of $320/unit. Unfortunately, due to the RAM shortage and other market factors, our preferred model is no longer available and a comparable device now runs $421.

This dramatic increase on the budget has led us to re-evaluate student Chromebook devices. For instance, after polling teachers, we've decided that a convertible (2-in-1) Chromebook isn't essential. Instead we will be getting a more traditional touchscreen "clamshell" Chromebook without tablet functionality. This drops the price closer to $370/unit. Class sizes in 2nd, 5th, and 12th grades are also down compared to last year, so we are able to purchase 100 fewer units overall. Lastly, we have requested demo units from other manufacturers (Acer, Lenovo, etc.) to see if they have a similar device that could meet our needs. In short, we are doing everything we can to stretch every dollar. With that said, all vendors have warned us to expect another price increase on March 31. I'll have another update next month.

Our second major evaluation impacts how we filter and manage student devices. We have used the same vendor for at least the past 5 years (GoGuardian), and our current, AEA-negotiated contract ends in June. Similar to Chromebooks, our renewal price was expected to jump by nearly 10%. However, we have negotiated with GoGuardian and received quotes from similar providers that indicate we should actually be able to ***save*** money on our next renewal. Over Spring Break we began evaluating several filtering and managing solutions and have identified three alternatives that will be moving forward in the process. Following internal testing, we will recruit several teachers to pilot these solutions "in the field" with the goal of bringing a recommendation to the board in May or June.

Finally, I want to mention the MacBook Neo. Apple announced the device earlier this month with aggressive pricing targeting schools ($494/unit). While we don't believe that this is the right direction for our 1-to-1 device initiative, we do see some potential. Specifically, we've purchased a Neo to test with our High School art courses to see if this device – which runs Adobe software that our Chromebooks cannot – would meet their academic needs at a lower price point than a full MacBook. Expect a recommendation on this device this summer as well.

Thanks to Business Manager Wearmouth for her collaboration on these impacts to the budget, and thanks to the board for their continued support of technology initiatives for the district.